

Ready to Read Cards for Paying Clients?

By the end of this course you will be able to sit down with a real client, lay out a spread, and deliver a clear, ethical reading from start to finish.



What This Course Covers

Four modules

75 minutes total

The deck, the vocabulary, the spreads, the ethics

Everything you need before your first paid reading

The 78-Card Deck — Your Working Tool

A standard tarot deck has exactly 78 cards

22 Major Arcana and 56 Minor Arcana

This structure has been consistent since the 15th century

The 1909 Rider-Waite-Smith deck is the standard starting point

https://collections.vam.ac.uk/item/O1028247/rider-waite-smith-deck-print-waite-arthur-edward/

The Major Arcana — 22 Cards, 0 Through 21

Each card represents a major life theme, archetype, or turning point

When Major Arcana cards appear, something significant is at stake

The sequence runs from The Fool (0) to The World (21)

https://collections.vam.ac.uk/item/O1028238/rider-waite-smith-deck-print-waite-arthur-edward/

The 22 Major Arcana in Order

0 The Fool — 1 The Magician — 2 The High Priestess — 3 The Empress — 4 The Emperor

5 The Hierophant — 6 The Lovers — 7 The Chariot — 8 Strength — 9 The Hermit

10 Wheel of Fortune — 11 Justice — 12 The Hanged Man — 13 Death — 14 Temperance

15 The Devil — 16 The Tower — 17 The Star — 18 The Moon — 19 The Sun

20 Judgement — 21 The World

The Minor Arcana — 56 Cards in Four Suits

Four suits — Wands, Cups, Swords, and Pentacles

Each suit has 14 cards: Ace through 10 plus four Court Cards

4 suits times 14 cards equals 56

https://collections.vam.ac.uk/item/O1028154

The Four Suits and What They Govern

Wands — Fire

creativity, action, ambition, career

Cups — Water

emotions, relationships, intuition, love

Swords — Air

thoughts, conflict, truth, decisions

Pentacles — Earth

money, work, health, material stability



Pip Cards and Court Cards

Pip cards (Ace through 10) cover day-to-day events in that suit's domain

Court Cards (Page, Knight, Queen, King) typically represent a real person in the client's life or an aspect of the client's own personality

Every suit has both — 10 pips and 4 Court Cards

Key Vocabulary You Will Use With Every Client

Querent

the person asking the question

Reader

the person interpreting the cards

Spread

the layout of cards

Position

one specific spot in a spread

Upright / Reversed

card orientation

Significator

a card chosen to represent the querent

Clarifier

an extra card drawn when a card's meaning is unclear

Why the Rider-Waite-Smith Deck

Published in 1909, illustrated by Pamela Colman Smith

First deck to give all 78 cards — including pip cards — a full illustrated scene

Visual scenes make interpretation possible without memorizing a fixed keyword list

This is the deck beginners start with

Watch: VIDEO LINK

Module 1 Practice — Name That Card

Tell your instructor beside the slide the name of one Major Arcana card and which number it holds

Your instructor will confirm whether you have it right

Ask to be drilled through several more if you want the practice

Step One — Form a Strong Question

The quality of a reading depends on the quality of the question

Vague: "What does the universe want me to know?"

Focused: "What do I need to understand about this job offer right now?"

Open questions outperform yes-or-no questions every time



Step Two — Prepare the Deck

Shuffle while holding the question in mind — this tunes the reading to the question

If the deck has been unused or handled by others, clear it first

Knocking on the deck, shuffling with intention, or another personal method all work



The One-Card Pull

One card drawn in answer to one focused question

The right spread for a simple, specific question

The essential starting point for every beginner





The Three-Card Spread

Three cards — three linked positions

Past, Present, Future — or Situation, Action, Outcome — or Mind, Body, Spirit

The bridge between single-card pulls and multi-card narratives

Use it when a client wants a fuller view without an overwhelming layout

The Celtic Cross — 10 Positions, One Complete Picture

Ten cards in a cross-plus-staff pattern

The first six cards form a central cross; four more form a vertical column to the right

Card 2 lays horizontally across Card 1

The most widely known spread for deep exploration of a situation

Watch: VIDEO LINK

Celtic Cross Positions 1 Through 5

1 Present / Heart of the Matter

What is the core of the situation right now?

2 Challenge / What Crosses You

What is the main obstacle or complicating force?

3 Past

What from the past has shaped this situation?

4 Foundation

What is the deeper root or unconscious basis of this situation?

5 Possible Outcome / Crown

What is the best possible outcome if things develop well?

Celtic Cross Positions 6 Through 10

1. **Future / What Approaches**

   What is coming in the near term?

2. **The Querent's Attitude**

   How does the client see themselves in this situation?

3. **Outside Influences**

   What people or forces around the client are affecting things?

4. **Hopes and Fears**

   What does the client most hope for or fear about the outcome?

5. **Final Outcome**

   Where is this situation heading if the current trajectory continues?

Interpreting Cards Within Their Positions

The position provides the question — the card provides the answer

The same card means something different in different positions

Before reading individual cards, survey the whole spread first

Note Major versus Minor Arcana, dominant suits, Court Cards, and repeating numbers



Module 2 Practice — Celtic Cross Position Drill

Ask your instructor beside the slide to call out one of the 10 position numbers

Tell your instructor the name of that position and what question it asks

Continue for as many positions as you want to practice





Reading Suit Patterns Across a Spread

Many Pentacles

practical or financial concerns are central

Many Cups

emotional and relational matters dominate

Many Swords

mental conflict, decisions, or difficult truths

Many Wands

action, momentum, and ambition are driving the reading

A dominant suit shows where the reading's attention is concentrated

How to Read the Celtic Cross as a Story

01

Start with the present and the challenge together

this frames the question

02

Look at the foundation and past

this explains how the situation developed

03

Consult the crown and future

this shows where things are heading

04

Work up the staff

querent's attitude, outside influences, hopes and fears, final outcome



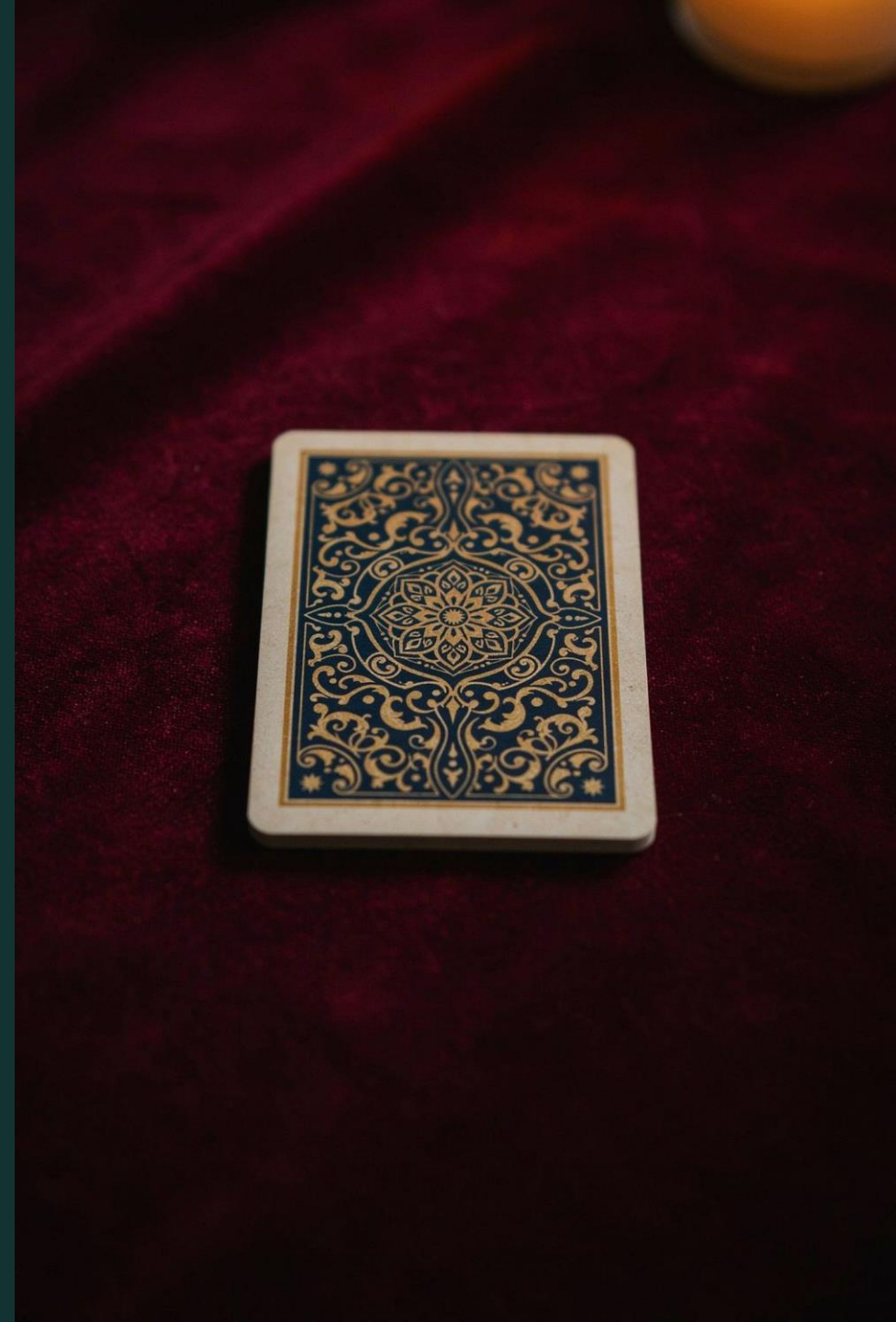
Reversed Cards — What They Are

A reversed card appears upside down from the reader's point of view

Reversals are entirely optional — many professional readers work upright only

Beginners: master upright meanings first, then add reversals once they feel automatic

A reversed card is not a different card — it is the same archetype in a different mode



Four Approaches to Reversed Cards

Opposite meaning

the reversal flips the upright to its shadow or contrary expression

Internalized energy

the same theme turned inward rather than outward

Blocked energy

the upright meaning is present but cannot express itself freely

Intensified or distorted energy

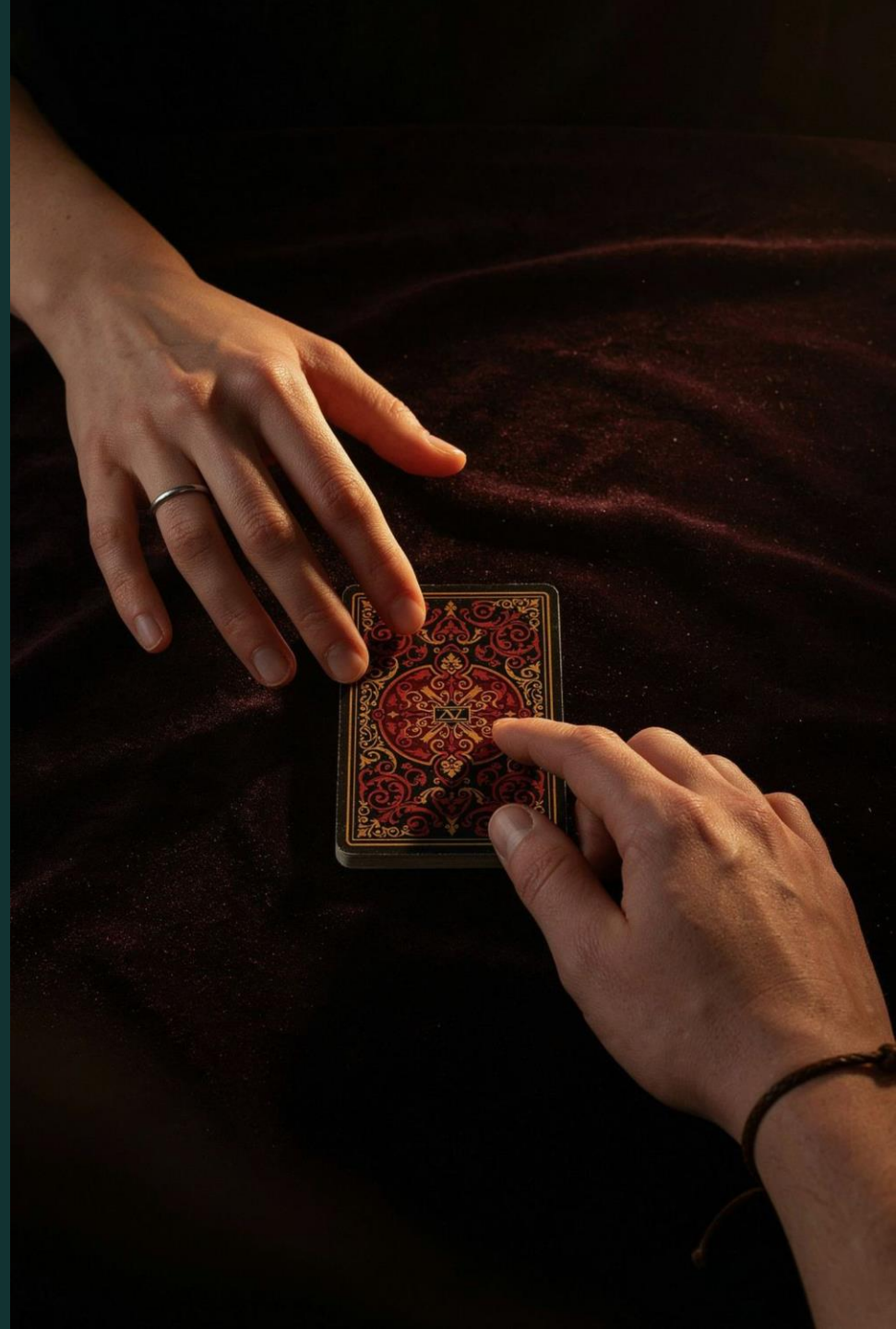
the upright meaning pushed to excess or distortion

The Practical Rule for Reversals

Start with the upright meaning of the reversed card

Then ask which of the four patterns fits — given the question, the surrounding cards, and the client's situation

Do not force a reversal reading if the upright meaning fits better





Module 3 Practice — Suit Pattern Role-Play

Ask your instructor beside the slide to name a suit and describe a brief client situation

Tell your instructor what that suit pattern signals and how you would open the story for the client

Try as many variations as you like

Framing Outcomes Ethically

The outcome card reflects where things are heading if nothing changes — not a fixed fate

Always frame it this way: "Based on where things are now, this is the direction things seem to be heading"

The client can change course — your job is to illuminate, not to predict





Handling Sensitive Topics

Avoid absolute predictions on health, finances, legal matters, and relationships

When a question requires professional expertise, acknowledge the limits of a tarot reading and encourage the client to consult the right professional

Avoid yes-or-no framings for complex, emotionally charged questions

Help clients reframe: "Will my marriage survive?" becomes "What do I need to understand about my marriage right now?"



Deliver a Story, Not a List

The client should leave with a connected narrative they can think about and act on

Ten isolated card meanings is not a reading — it is a list

The story lives in the links between positions

Building Your Skills — The Recommended Sequence

Stage 1

Daily one-card pulls with journal entries

Stage 2

Three-card spreads, connecting three positions into a small story

Stage 3

Celtic Cross readings for yourself and trusted practice partners

Stage 4

Add reversals once upright meanings feel automatic

Only then take paying clients for the full Celtic Cross experience



The Tarot Journal — Your Most Important Practice Tool

Record every reading: which cards appeared in which positions and your initial impressions

Revisit entries later and note what actually happened

Over time the journal reveals patterns and shows how your interpretation has matured

This is the single most reliable path to reading fluency





Module 4 Practice — Sensitive Question Reframing

Ask your instructor beside the slide to give you a sample sensitive client question

Tell your instructor how you would reframe it into a focused, open prompt

Then explain to your instructor how you would present that reframe to the client so they feel supported

Deliver a Story, Not a List

The client should leave with a connected narrative they can think about and act on

Ten isolated card meanings is not a reading — it is a list

The story lives in the links between positions



Building Your Skills — The Recommended Sequence

01

Stage 1

Daily one-card pulls with journal entries

02

Stage 2

Three-card spreads, connecting three positions into a small story

03

Stage 3

Celtic Cross readings for yourself and trusted practice partners

04

Stage 4

Add reversals once upright meanings feel automatic

05

Stage 5

Only then take paying clients for the full Celtic Cross experience



The Tarot Journal — Your Most Important Practice Tool

Record every reading: which cards appeared in which positions and your initial impressions

Revisit entries later and note what actually happened

Over time the journal reveals patterns and shows how your interpretation has matured

This is the single most reliable path to reading fluency

Module 4 Practice — Sensitive Question Reframing

Ask your instructor beside the slide to give you a sample sensitive client question

Tell your instructor how you would reframe it into a focused, open prompt

Then explain to your instructor how you would present that reframe to the client so they feel supported





Optional Knowledge Check

A private knowledge check is available to confirm your grasp of deck structure, spread positions, suit meanings, and ethical framing

Nothing is recorded — this is just for you

Ask your instructor beside the slide to begin when you are ready

You Are Ready to Begin

You now have the structure, the vocabulary, the spreads, and the ethical foundation for a paying practice

Your next step: pull one card today, write your first journal entry, and begin Stage 1

Your instructor is here whenever you want to keep practicing

